

Do not mistake activity for appearance

Positional Judgment

THE IDEA

A piece is active when it performs useful work: attacking targets, controlling entry squares, supporting threats, or restricting enemy pieces. A central location can look impressive while accomplishing little. Judge influence against the position's needs.

WORKED EXAMPLE

A knight on e5 may dominate if it attacks weaknesses and cannot be chased. If it only looks central while a rook invades your second rank, defending the invasion may matter more than preserving the knight's pose.

TRY IT BEFORE READING ON

How can you test whether a piece is really active?

ANSWER AND REASONING

Name the concrete moves or restrictions it creates. If removing it changes little, its apparent activity may be less important than another piece's defensive role.

TAKE THIS INTO YOUR NEXT GAME

Measure activity through tasks and consequences.